

FAN STORY  
DOCTOR WHO  
ELIZABETH  
AND THE  
TRAIN



By Kyle Young



## **The Last Of The Old Time Lords**

In the hush of a lightless room, Elizabeth strikes a match. The head flares, sulfur bright, and she cups the flame near her face. Around her, children huddle in Halloween costumes, masks askew and eyes wide. One whispers, “How are we going to get out of this one?”

“Listen,” Elizabeth breathes. “Do you hear it?”

From somewhere beyond the walls comes that impossible sound—the wheeze-groan of an ancient engine folding the world around it. The TARDIS. Its echo shivers through the dark.

“There was once a madman in a blue box,” Elizabeth says, voice steady as a vow. “A man who fought gods and outwitted Time itself. Who watched the Flux tear half the universe apart—and stopped it. A man who has known more loss than we can imagine. Who has condemned as many as he has saved. Who walks the length of time and the breadth of space, setting things right. One of the last of the old Time Lords.

“He’s saved you more times than you’ll ever know. You’ve watched his life play out before your eyes. And he will always do his best to save you—no matter who you are. He is the one who will save us.”

The match gutters, spits amber, and dies. Darkness swallows everything.



## Elizabeth

Britain, London — 1940. 5:00 p.m.

Soot falls like slow snow, turning the light to smoke. Elizabeth keeps one palm on the cold flank of the train as she hurries the platform toward the last carriage. Sirens moan. Steam hisses. The world is fifty metres wide and shrinking.

At the final carriage, soldiers wrestle a large blue box up the steps. A captain—voice raw, temper razor—snaps, “Move!”

Elizabeth steps into his path. “Why are we loading a blue box? This space could carry the wounded—men who need it.”

He rakes her with a glance, dismissive. “You’re a nurse. You wouldn’t understand. These are... cultural assets.”

A soldier slips. The box thuds. The grime slides, and three letters peer through: POL.

Elizabeth lets her fury show. “Splendid job safeguarding culture, then.”

The captain turns away to bellow more orders. She turns too, into the train’s hot iron breath.

Carriage after carriage is jammed—bandaged brows, burned hands, boots tracking rain and blood. In the first she enters, a man in a bright orange coat lies sprawled on the floor. Scars ladder his face. He can’t be more than twenty-five.

A soldier catches Elizabeth’s sleeve. “I’m sorry—this man was just outside. Can you help him?”

Elizabeth steadies her breath, offers a small, certain smile. “I’ll try.”

The soldier keeps one arm under the stranger, reluctant to let go. “Frank,” he says, almost as an afterthought—as if her calm knocks his name loose.

Elizabeth takes his free hand, quick and sure. “Elizabeth.” Her gaze flicks to the dark stains on his uniform. “You’re hurt.”

He blinks, then down, then back to her. “Not mine,” he says, as if waking. “Someone else’s.”

She kneels, brushing back the coat collar, checking pupils and pulse. “I thought all the civilians were already moved out.”

Frank lowers the man carefully to the floor, still watching Elizabeth more than the task. “So did I. He turned up anyway. Said he was a doctor—right before he collapsed.”

Elizabeth exhales, setting down her kit. “Then let’s see what kind.”

For a heartbeat they hold each other’s eyes; the noise of the train thins to a hum. Frank’s tension eases into the ghost of a smile he hasn’t earned yet.

“Thank you,” she says, gentle but decisive. “I’ll take it from here.”

Frank doesn’t move. “Do you…” He swallows, surprised by his own voice. “Do you have plans after this?”

Elizabeth blinks, amused. “After the train ride? Not really.”

His ears color; he presses on anyway. “If we get through—maybe I could take you out?”

She arches a brow. “Shouldn’t you ask if I’m married first?”

“Are you?”

“No.” A smile now. “I just wanted to see what you’d do.”

He lets out a breath like surfacing. “So… dinner?”

“Always,” she teases. “Where to, Fly Boy?”

“Fly Boy?”

She tilts her head toward his trousers. “Your fly’s down. Everyone needs a nickname.”

He glances down, mortified, zips fast, then laughs—lighter now. “Right. My bad. Then what’s yours?”

“Isn’t that your job?”

“Next time I see you, I’ll have one.”

“I look forward to it. How will I find you after the ride?”

"I'm up front," he says, almost proud again. "Driving the train."

"Then it's a date," she replies, already turning back to her patient.

Frank gives her one last, dazed smile and hurries down the carriage toward the engine.

Elizabeth exhales. Her focus snaps to the man in the orange coat. She drops to her knees, fingers finding the pulse at his throat—

The captain from the platform vaults aboard, breath fogging. "Captain Jacob," he manages, softer now. "Sorry about before. The train's late." The carriage lurches as the wheels bite the rails. He scans the wounded. "Where's the doctor?"

Elizabeth swallows. "It's just me this time."

His jaw tightens. "Do your best, then. I'll be watching the art at the back." He shoulders through toward the last carriage.



## You Really Don't Know Who I Am

Elizabeth looks down—and freezes. The stranger's wounds aren't healing; they're closing, knitting from the edges. A warm gold unspools off his skin like sunlight trapped in smoke. His eyes snap open. He sees her and grins—dazed, delighted. “Wow.”

He lurches upright, winces, braces on a seat. “Where are we, Elizabeth?”

She startles. “You... know my name?”

His gaze skitters over bandages, stretchers, boots; the packed bodies; the furnace-breath of steam. “Injured people.” He steps past her, drifting toward a soldier with a tin mug. “You all right, mate?”

The soldier blinks. “Er—are you?”

The man plucks the mug, takes a sip, and immediately spits it out. “Tea. Good. Britain.” He hands the mug back with an apologetic wince. “Sorry. Needed to be sure.” His eyes flick to the uniforms, the insignia, the cut of cloth. “Uniforms. Wartime. Forties.”

He pivots back to Elizabeth, setting warm, steady hands on her shoulders as she checks his pupils—the glow already thinning to a ghost along his skin. “Looks like World War Two. Wait—are we on Earth?”

He glances out the window: a sky of soot. “Earth,” he decides, satisfied.

She arches a brow, still holding his wrist; heat thrums under her fingers. “Of course we're on Earth. Been visiting other planets recently?”

He finally really looks at her—cap, uniform, the set of her jaw—and some of the wild brightness in his eyes settles. “You don't know who I am, do you?”

She can't help smiling. “No. Somehow you know who I am.”

“Name tag,” he says, flashing teeth.

Elizabeth glances down—ash smears her badge. She wipes it clean: ELIZABETH. When she looks up, he's already pacing, barefoot focus in a borrowed body.

"Earth. Forties. Somewhere in Britain. Ash in the sky..." He tilts his head, listening to thunder that isn't weather. "Battle of Britain. Maybe a Blitz night."

"We think the Luftwaffe will hit again tonight," she says, thinner than she means to.

The train rattles into the dark; above, London burns. The impossible warmth ebbs from her hands and—just for a moment—the smoke in her lungs tastes a little like hope.

He sways. Elizabeth is up in an instant, catching him as he pitches forward, eyes flaring with that impossible light.

"This part," he rasps, blinking hard, "always takes getting used to. Biogeneration keeps the body healing until it's too far gone."

She keeps him upright. "You're sure you're all right?"

His gaze runs over her—curious, bright. "You really don't know who I am?"

Elizabeth lets out a breathless laugh. "I'd remember a man in an orange coat—and a face that... distinctive."

He squints, half-wounded, half-proud. "So now I'm ugly?"

"Don't put words in my mouth."

"Fair enough." He plants his feet and straightens, standing on his own. "It's not just the words we say—it's the order we say them."

"I couldn't have said it better," she replies—

—but his eyes spark and he's suddenly patting himself down: coat, trousers, pockets. Frantic, like a man who's misplaced the end of the world.

"Where is that old thing? I always—ah." He brightens. "Found you."

He draws out a metal, penlike device. It wakes in his hand, a soft glow gathering at the tip.

"What are you looking for?" she asks.

He catches the worry in her face and gives a crooked, apologetic smile, one hand raised to steady her. "It's all right. Just a temporal scan. Trying to check a hunch."

"Right about what?"

"When and where we are," he lies cheerfully, eyes flicking to the tiny screen as the glow deepens. He pockets it, nerves turning into motion, and rubs his hands together. "Okay. There's a reason I'm here. There's always a reason."

"Well, you're a doctor, aren't you? You can help some of these soldiers," Elizabeth says.

He meets her eyes. "Yes and no." A beat. "I'm not a doctor... I'm the Doctor. The original one, you might say."

"What does that even mean?"

But he's already out of the carriage. She hurries after him. "You can't just drop 'I'm the Doctor' and walk off!"

He sweeps the device through the air—circles, lines, quick impatient jabs—like he's tracking a scent only he can smell.

"And what are you doing now?" she demands.

"Hunting disturbances." He tips her a glance, mischief and gravity at once. "The TARDIS drops me where I'm needed. She's got a nose for trouble."

The device flickers red.

"At this rate," Elizabeth mutters, keeping pace, "you're in danger of me hitting you."

"Hold that thought," he murmurs, not unkindly, and pushes through the next door.

They pass the wounded—bandaged heads, soot-streaked faces. He moves like a man late for an appointment with fate, pausing only to squeeze a shoulder and murmur, "You'll get through this. Stay with me," before the device tugs him onward.

Carriage to carriage, the light swells—blue to brighter blue, a heartbeat in his palm. The hum thickens to a thrumming purr that vibrates the bones of the train. Shadows tilt toward it. Steam answers with a hiss.

They reach the last carriage.

The glow is dazzling now, washing the walls in cold aurora. The air feels wrong—too still, too neat, like a room holding its breath.

The Doctor's eyes dance. "There you are," he whispers to the silence. "Knew you were hiding at the end."

The Doctor's hand is on the door when Elizabeth steps in front of it. He turns, eyebrows up.

"And what exactly are you doing?" he asks. "I thought you'd be off... doing nurse-y things. Helping people."



"I would be," she says, arms folded, "but my patient—who claims to be a doctor—keeps walking away from me."

"I'm not claiming to be the Doctor," he says, letting go of the handle. "I am the Doctor."

She tilts her head. "Doctor who?"

His face lights like a match. "Could you say that again?"

She blinks. "Doctor who?"

He beams, almost boyish. "I forget how much I like people asking that."

He swings the door open—then freezes. The carriage beyond is empty. Benches pristine. Not a scuff, not a smear. Silence where there should be groans and orders and life.

"That's... odd," Elizabeth says, stepping in beside him. "This carriage was full."

His smile thins to thoughtfulness. "Oh, that's disappointing. I was hoping for something obvious. Obvious is easy."

"Where's Captain Jacob?" she presses. "He said he'd be here."

The Doctor crosses to the far wall and lays his palm to the wood. He frowns, listening with his fingertips. Elizabeth watches him, suspicion flaring.

"When I think about it," she says, "things only started getting strange when you turned up in your orange coat. What have you done? Where is Captain Jacob? What was that... glow on you earlier? And what is that?" She points to the metal device in his hand.

"This?" He lifts it. "This is a sonic screwdriver. And among the very many things it can do—"

He clicks it on. A clean hum threads the air. The "wood" shivers—and peels away revealing metal. Panels blink awake, screens blossom from the now metal walls, lenses iris open like mechanical flowers. The cosy timber of a railway carriage melts into a skin of glass and metal: a room pretending to be a train.

Elizabeth staggers back, eyes wide. The Doctor paces, sonicking along seams and corners, chasing echoes only he can hear.

"How did you know it wasn't wood?" she asks.

"The sonic is rubbish on wood," he says, delighted. "Which meant if it worked, this wasn't wood. And if it wasn't wood... hello, secrets."

He pockets the screwdriver, then pries a panel free. Behind it: a thicket of cables, lights winking like distant cities. He crouches, grinning, a child with a new toy and a bomb at the same time.

“This isn’t just a dressing room for illusions,” he murmurs. “It’s a transit hub—a teleporter pretending to be a carriage. You did say this last car was crammed with... stuff.”

“I did,” Elizabeth says, stepping beside him. “So you do listen to me.”

“Sometimes,” he says, pleased. He pinches a thick cable. “Controller line. This is how ‘here’ talks to ‘there’.”

He raises the sonic, then pauses, suddenly serious. “Last chance to step off. I don’t know where this goes. I don’t know if it’s safe.”

Elizabeth looks at the empty benches, thinks of the vanished wounded, feels the room holding its breath. She squares her shoulders.

“We all need a little danger.”

His smile returns, sharper now. “That’s the spirit.”

He sonics the cable. Screens wake—first cold blue, then warning red, then both, pulsing like twin heartbeats. The air tightens. The floor trembles.



## Bow Tie, Fez And Orange Coat

A sharp knock rattles the door.

The Doctor lifts the sonic. The walls ripple; reality shivers. The “teleporter” skins itself into a dreary janitor’s closet—mop, bucket, a bleach smell that feels like a lie. Elizabeth edges in behind him.

He flicks the sonic across the threshold. “Male. Human.” The hum fades; he lowers it.

“‘Just’ another human?” Elizabeth asks, one brow up.

Before he can answer, the door swings open. A harried man in a bow tie peers in, ticking them off like items on a list. “Finally. Are you the servicers I’ve been waiting on for the last five minutes?”

The Doctor steps forward without missing a beat. “Yes. Of course.”

The man’s gaze travels from their shoes to their hair and back. “What are you wearing?”

Elizabeth and the Doctor trade a look. “Clothes,” she says.

“Not good enough for a black-tie event,” he snaps. “Come on. We’ve got spares.”

He sweeps them into a maze of service corridors—steam pipes, rattling trolleys, the dull thunder of a party just beyond the walls. He barks instructions as he speed-walks.

“Rules: always be polite. If you drop your tray, clean it fast. Run out of anything—tray behind your back, fetch more immediately. If you spill on someone, don’t argue; take what they say. These people make more in a day than I’ll see in ten years. To them, you’re furniture. To them, they’re your gods for tonight. Clear?”

He stops at a door and thumbs it open. Inside is a wardrobe the size of a chapel. Racks of tuxedos and gowns gleam under cold lights.

“And hurry up,” he adds, already moving. “You’re due out there now.”

The door hushes shut. The Doctor and Elizabeth share a look; mischief sparks at the corners of his mouth.

He steps into the forest of suits, rubbing fabric between finger and thumb, then lights up at a shock of color. “Oh, hello.” He lifts a long orange coat to his shoulders like greeting an old friend. “Well. I know what I’m wearing.”

Elizabeth trails a hand over a gown that shifts where she touches it—ink to midnight to aurora. She startles, then laughs. “People really wear these? They’re not dresses—they’re... suggestions.”

The Doctor shrugs into the orange coat, grabs a few accessories, and vanishes into the next room. Elizabeth’s eyes spark when she finds something worthy of the night: a gown that shimmers from ink-black to snow-white with every breath.

Outside the changing room, the Doctor waits with two silver trays balanced on one arm. Elizabeth steps out; her dress catches the light like moonbeams underwater.

“How do I look?” she asks, smiling.

He takes her in—face, posture, the small tremor of excitement in her hands. “Good. Great. Irrelevant. We’re here to spot anyone who stands out—anyone out of place.”

“I think I look great,” she says, baffled but pleased.

He squints. “Did you hear anything I just said?”

“I heard ‘out of place.’” Her gaze drops to him—and stalls. “What are you wearing?”

He brightens. “Bow tie, fez, orange coat.” He says it like a magic trick.

She plucks the fez off his head and sets it neatly on the floor. “The changing room has lights, you know.”

“Yes, of course. Why—”

“Because you look like you dressed in the dark. And what is with the hat?”

“It’s a fez. Fezzes are cool.”

“Not on your head.” She straightens his bow tie, then steps back. “Better.”

He sighs, fond and theatrical. “Fine. The fez can sit this dance out. But we go in looking for anomalies: wrong shoes on the right feet, laughter half a beat late, people who don’t breathe with the music.”

Elizabeth lifts the second tray from his hand. “Two outsiders hunting for outsiders. What could go wrong?”

He crooks his arm. “Shall we go meet the gods?”

"We shall," she says, taking it.

They shoulder through the service door into a cathedral of glass: a vast dome arcing overhead, the night beyond black as ink and crowded with unfamiliar constellations. Chandeliers hang from iron ribs like tame comets. Hundreds mingle below—silk and alloy, human and not—while a polished metal cylinder stands at the center like a monument that arrived before the walls.

"We split up," the Doctor murmurs.

Elizabeth nods. She drifts left with a tray; the Doctor peels right, already scanning. He sets his tray by a pillar, eyes lifting to the sky.

"Those aren't Earth's stars," he says to no one—delighted and troubled at once. "Off-world. New sky. Never seen that pattern."

Something brushes his ankle. He looks down: a quick, golden creature—fur like wire, eyes like coins—scurries past, paying out an actual cable from its mouth. It vanishes under a wall panel. He follows the line with his gaze, then with his feet, threading through the crowd toward the cylinder.

Elizabeth works the room's edges, slipping her tray onto a sideboard, letting her eyes do the sorting—posture, footwork, smiles that arrive a beat late. She bumps a tall guest; a crystal glass spins and shatters. The alien's skin flushes from tranquil blue to warning red.

"Sorry—" Elizabeth begins, but the reply is a language of metallic clatter.

A woman appears at her shoulder, hand light and sure. "My friend wasn't watching where she was going. She's taken with the stars."

The alien cools back to blue. A curt nod. Gone.

Elizabeth exhales. "Thank you. How did you know that would work?"

"They're Enranthka," the woman says, guiding her aside. "Underground species. Toxic skies. They live beneath the earth; soil is their shield. Seeing stars is... seeing a god."

They stop. The woman's hand slips away.

Elizabeth smiles. "Then—thank you. I should—"

"What's your play?" the woman asks, voice soft, eyes sharp.

"I don't know what you mean."

"I think you do." The woman looks her over, head to toe. "You look extraordinary. Possibly the most beautiful thing in this room. But you're in black. Enranthka wear bright colors for a newborn celebration—which this is. Black is disrespect."

Heat climbs Elizabeth's cheeks. She glances at the shimmering gown. "Why didn't the Doctor tell me?"

The woman goes still. “The Doctor is here?”

Confidence slips; fear shows. Elizabeth sees the opening.

“Tell me your name—and why you’re here—and I’ll tell you what I know.”

A quiet standoff. No flinch. No blink.

“My first name was Ciara,” the woman says at last. “Most people know me by something else. I’m here to make sure my employees work and my client stays happy.”

“What does your client do?”

Ciara’s smile doesn’t reach her eyes. “Cute. Your turn.”

Elizabeth keeps her voice airy. “I don’t know where the Doctor is. We split up when we arrived.”

Ciara freezes—not outwardly, but in the muscles around her eyes. A private calculus ticks behind them. You can almost see her redrawing lines: entry points, exits, contingencies. Where could he slip a wrench? Which hinge could he kick? How fast could he ruin the night?

She nods once, decision made. “Well played.” She turns—then stops, gaze snagging on the center of the room. The cylinder’s silver skin is deepening to blue. Light blooms along its seams like ice catching fire. “Good luck with the Doctor,” she says, and melts into the crowd.

Elizabeth follows her look—and spots him across the floor: the Doctor, speed-walking with purpose, cradling a glowing blue sphere like a stolen heart. He sees the color climbing the cylinder.

“Oh, that’s not good,” he says, and takes off.

“Run!” he calls to Elizabeth as he zips past—arms pumping, legs flinging, a chaotic marionette of urgency.

Despite the stakes, a laugh slips out of her—bright, involuntary. He runs like a cartoon cowboy kicked from behind. Guards pivot; a few break into pursuit. Elizabeth grabs a tray for cover and sprints after him, ducking through a service door as the dome’s roar collapses into hush. Behind them: locks clack, doors seal, blue light climbs, stars retreat.

She turns, still breathless, still laughing. The Doctor cradles the sphere; its glow crawls over his knuckles like lightning learning manners.

“Why do you run like that—and what did you do?”

He grins, already spinning the orb between his palms. “Borrowed a power source. Mid-cycle, by the look of it.” He squints at her. “Wait—are you saying I run funny?”

“Hilarious,” she says, fighting another laugh. “Also: it’s getting brighter.”

“Because when I lifted it off the central console, it was halfway through waking something.” Click—click—click. The sphere sings under his fingers. “It’s overloading. I just need the right rotational harmonics and—”

The blue flares toward white. Elizabeth flinches, eyes squeezed shut. The clicks race, stutter—and then, with one deft twist:

“Yes!” The light settles into a steady ember. A small, calm blue heart.

She opens her eyes. “You did not know that would work.”

“I had confidence,” he says, cheerfully unrepentant.

She gives him a look. “Where did you even get it?”

“Little gold-furred engineers were lacing a cable lattice around it—like a triform trap, only ballroom-sized.”

“What’s a triform trap?” Elizabeth asks.

“Locks your feet to the floor so you can’t move,” the Doctor says. “Got stuck in one once.”

Footsteps thunder closer—many, fast. He meets her eyes. “What did you find?”

“That this party is an Enranthka newborn celebration,” Elizabeth says. “And there’s a woman—Ciara—who looks out of place.”

The Doctor’s ears prick. “Ciara. Black hair, green diamond on her forehead, star tattoo on her right hand?”

Elizabeth blinks. “Yes. How did you—”

“That’s not good,” he mutters.

Security floods the corridor—armor, visors, rifles leveled. The Doctor lifts an easy smile, slips the cooled sphere—the power source for the triform, same tech as a triform trap—behind his back, and palms it into Elizabeth’s hand without looking.

“Evening!” he calls, stepping in front of her, hiding the sphere. “How can I help?”

“Hands where we can see them,” the lead officer snaps. “Drop everything and come quietly.”

The Doctor tilts his head. “What if we’re holding a bomb, and dropping it sets it off? Wise?” The officers falter; he keeps one hand in his coat, sonic angled. “Do you have a bomb?” the lead asks.

“No,” the Doctor says, thumbing the sonic. A warble—safeties click, rifles die. “But we do have legs. Run!”

He grabs Elizabeth’s free hand and the two sprint. Shots crack late and useless as he slams a door, sonics the lock. “Deadlocked. They won’t be getting through—”

The lights die.

“No, not now.” He flicks the sonic to lantern mode, a thin cone of blue guiding them through dark service halls. “Control room,” he pants. “Power’s answer will be there.”

They burst through a final bulkhead as the lights strobe back to life—without either of them touching a thing. Captain Jacob stands at a control panel with a woman who levels a pistol: Amelia.

“Why are you here again? Can’t you just disappear?” she says, cold. “You’ve already ruined the first plan.”

The Doctor’s voice goes quiet. “If your plan is to hurt people—to murder them for power, to conquer or burn—then listen. I’m the last of the old Time Lords. I know what ruin costs. If you kill anyone in that ballroom—or anyone on this ship—I will stop you. One way or another.”

Captain Jacob laughs, delighted and terrible. “You’re already late. Look.”

He points to the small window in the door behind them. The Doctor and Elizabeth turn. Beyond the glass, the ballroom’s dome shimmers, then crazes. Fractures spiderweb, then fail. Air howls. Bodies lift. A shield snaps on, but too late; the guests drift, limp, in the sudden stillness.

Elizabeth crumples, tears streaking. “They’re all dead.”

Captain Jacob smiles. “What a strong man you are, Doctor. Still couldn’t save them.”

The Doctor clenches his jaw as he looks closer to see something, something no one else can see. “Well done. You’ve made an enemy for life. But this feels above your pay grade. Who’s your boss?”

Amelia steps forward. “You think we’re not smart enough to pull this off?”

The Doctor starts to pace—circling the room, deliberately turning his back on Elizabeth, voice sharpening as he thinks aloud. “Your first plan used a triform trap to pin targets. But you didn’t want to be seen laying cable. So you got help.”

“Ciara,” Elizabeth says hoarsely.

“Yes—Ciara, the so-called Goblin Queen,” the Doctor says. “You laid the lines for a mass triform trap, powered by this very sphere I just removed. Job one: immobilize the living and teleport them out. You failed. And now they’re dead.”

He stops, looks from Amelia to Captain Jacob. “So why triform at all? What do the living have in common with the dead?” A beat. “Bodies. You’re building an army of the dead. But there’s one thing you didn’t plan for.”

Elizabeth has been edging behind them. The Doctor’s smile is small and sad. “Her.”



Elizabeth hurls the sphere between Amelia and Captain Jacob. The Doctor snaps the sonic—pure white blooms; the blast is concussive, blinding. Amelia and Captain Jacob cry out, staggering.

The Doctor wheels—something moves at the corridor's corner: a man in an orange coat, watching. The Doctor's eyes widen. He darts past Elizabeth, then past the dazed conspirators, hooks left into a side passage, and pelts through another hallway—back, breath ragged, toward the janitor's room.

Behind him, alarms wail. Ahead, the quiet stink of cleaning solvent. He slams the janitor's door, presses his back to it,

The Doctor steps into the teleport room and sets the controls to send him back to just after he and Elizabeth first arrived.

"I shouldn't cross my own timeline," he muttered, "but the window didn't make sense. It showed only humans. This party isn't just humans. And the man in the orange jacket—that was me. I can still save them."



## You Naughty Boy

The room flashed, and he reappeared. Ahead, his past self and Elizabeth were already following the waiter. The Doctor shadowed them at a safe distance along the walkway.

“Hurry up,” the waiter called as he moved off. “You’re due out there now.”

Past-Doctor and Elizabeth ducked into the wardrobe. The present Doctor kept going, slipping into the glass-domed ballroom. He crossed to the far side, studying a small “window” in a service door. He raised his sonic.

“It’s not a window,” he said. “It’s a screen.”

He glanced up, spotted a camera above the door, and sonicked it—hacking the feed and copying its data. He turned, took in the party one more time, then unlocked the door and stepped into the control room.

At the console, he scrubs through the recordings and finds the same “window” view—a staged dome failure. Then the Doctor presses a hand to his face, watching the figures drift. “They must have simulated every scenario—see what they could fix before it went wrong.”

He levels the sonic at the panel, routes the fake feed to the door screen, and hunts for the power controls. A bulky machine sits over the main switch. He points the sonic at it. “Someone else has taken control of the power—but who?”

The door slides open behind him.

Ciara steps in.

“You,” the Doctor said.

“And you,” Ciara answered.

He hopped off part of the panel, circling. “So your goblins laid the trap lines for the ballroom. How’d you get mixed up with this lot?”

Ciara mirrored his steps. “How are you here? You were just running toward Elizabeth—and now you’re here. How?”

“That doesn’t matter,” the Doctor said. “Why are you working for them?”

Ciara smiled, meeting his eyes. “Oh, you naughty boy. You’ve jumped back along your own timeline. You once told me I run in the shadows. And here you are, breaking your own rules.”

“Some rules are meant to be broken,” he said lightly. “And I can see the vortex manipulator on your wrist. If the goblins can time-jump without you, why are you still here? What are you waiting for?”

They stopped circling. He glanced at her hands, then nodded. “You haven’t been paid.”

Another door slid open. The Doctor darted into the corner where he’d seen the man in the orange coat before.

Ciara turned toward the newcomers. “Jacob. Amelia. The job’s done. The cable is laid. Now—my payment?”

Jacob looked to Amelia. “Pay her.”

Amelia smiled, drew a pistol, and leveled it at Ciara. “Let’s see if you actually did the job.”

Jacob worked a control. He tried to activate the trap. Nothing happened.

“Why isn’t it working?” Amelia snapped, raising the gun.

Ciara didn’t flinch. “Not my fault—or my team’s. The goblins did their job. Now where’s my payment?”

Amelia stepped closer and pressed the muzzle to Ciara’s forehead. “If you’d done your job, everyone in that room would be frozen.”

Ciara held her gaze. “Were you ever going to pay me?”

“Of course,” Amelia said, reaching for the bag on her back.

Ciara’s smile sharpened. “That will do.”

She flicked a switch on her manipulator. The lights died. In the dark shuffle, Ciara slipped the bag off Amelia’s shoulder and vanished in a time-flash.

“You clever girl,” the Doctor breathed.

“She just took the cash and left!” Amelia barked. “What do we do now?”

Jacob jabbed at controls. “Plan A was to teleport everyone to ‘Bob’ in orbit—injure them so the microbots could take over. But if we kill them, the microbots can still animate the dead. If I overload the dome’s shield, we can drop the glass.”

The Doctor waited, hidden. Lights surged back on. In the corridor beyond, he heard footsteps—his past self and Elizabeth arriving.

He stayed still, keeping time with himself, waiting for the past to catch up to the present.

Elizabeth squeezes her eyes shut against the white glare. When she forces them open, Amelia's gun is inches from her face.

"Well," Jacob says, "your great Doctor has left you behind."

Elizabeth glances around—the Doctor is gone.

"Yep," Amelia purrs. "Now it's just you and me."

Jacob rolls up his sleeve to reveal a device on his wrist. "Time to release the microbots."

Behind them, the Doctor slips out of the shadows, circling with silent hand signals to Elizabeth: keep them talking. She nods.

"Wait," Elizabeth says to Jacob. He lowers his hand, annoyed. "You need people, right? Why not pick a bigger event?"

"Oh, is this the part where we tell you our whole plan?" Amelia mocks, jamming the gun harder against Elizabeth's head.

While they're distracted, the Doctor flicks his sonic at Jacob's wrist device—then at a control panel—working fast.

"You might as well," Elizabeth says evenly. "You're going to shoot me anyway. And like the Doctor said, you need bodies—an army of the dead. If I'm 'fighting' for you, I want to know why."

The Doctor has already cracked the system, but he hesitates, listening.

Jacob looks to Amelia. "Worth wasting breath?"

Amelia shrugs. "We don't know the whole thing. Bob has a plan that will change everything."

"Change how?" the Doctor asks, stepping into view.

Jacob and Amelia whirl toward him—Jacob slams a button. A door irises open and a black wave of microbots floods in.

"You're trying to kill them all," the Doctor snaps. "You're stealing lives for a goal you don't even understand. You shout 'change,' but you don't know what you're changing. All you've stood for is death."

Microbots surge around them. Jacob and Amelia open fire, but the swarm knits into a shimmering cell, enclosing them. Elizabeth risks a look into the ballroom: the guests are alive, safe behind sealed partitions, while more microbots spew from the central cylinder.

"I warned you," the Doctor says, voice hard. "Stop and walk away. You didn't. So I'll treat you like monsters."

Jacob and Amelia scream as the swarm tightens.

“You can stop now!” Elizabeth pleads.

The Doctor doesn’t answer, eyes locked on the writhing cloud.

“You can stop now,” she says again, closer.

He finally looks at her. “Would they? This isn’t the first place they’ve done this, and it won’t be the last. They’re hopping through space and time—in little pockets—murdering people at parties, at funerals. Just enough victims to stay under the New Time Lords’ threshold of 5 thousand people with time ripples.”

Elizabeth steps in, cups his face, and meets his eyes. “Then you’re as bad as they are.”

The Doctor drops his gaze, lifts the sonic, and aims at the panel. Lights flare. The microbots loosen. Jacob and Amelia stop screaming.

“I already pinged the New Time Lords—the timeline cops,” the Doctor says, breath unsteady. “The swarm wasn’t killing them. It was restraining, cutting, then healing—repeating.”

He checks the sonic’s readout—and freezes. “Wait. This says they just came from the train. They came for the train. They may have taken the soldiers.”

He bolts for the ballroom. Elizabeth sprints after him.

As they both run to the teleporter taking them back



## **We've Got Two Choices**

London, 1940. Train steel hums underfoot. Ozone becomes soot. The Doctor steps out of the carriage and opens his arms.

"Welcome home."

Elizabeth moves into the next carriage, the Doctor close behind. At first, relief floods her—every soldier is standing, wounds gone, uniforms clean. But then they all turn at once, eyes glinting black as oil.

The Doctor's smile dies. "Elizabeth... they're not themselves anymore."

She steps toward one, hand trembling as she cups his cheek. "But they're upright. They look like them. They must still be here, somewhere."

The Doctor lifts his sonic screwdriver, scanning the room. The whirr rises, sharp and final. "No. The microbots are all that's left. They're wearing the bodies like suits."

Elizabeth turns, tears bright in her eyes. "That can't be true. Look—look at them. They're breathing."

The Doctor's gaze hardens. "Are they?"

Her hand jerks to the nearest soldier, tearing open his shirt. She presses her palm against his chest, then his stomach—waiting for any rise, any flicker of life. Nothing.

And then—movement. But not the kind she'd hoped for.

The soldiers stiffen in unison, heads tilting, limbs aligning. Their boots scrape as they fall into formation.

"Doctor—" Elizabeth whispers.

He grabs her hand, pulling her back as the line of black-eyed soldiers begins to march forward.

"They're not coming for us," he says, studying their rigid precision. "They've been summoned. Recalled to base."

The Doctor slammed the carriage door, the echo ringing like a warning bell. He turned to Elizabeth—brisk voice, eyes bright with decision.

“We’ve got two choices. One: cut the signal and shut the time machine down—sever whatever’s pulling them. Two: let it run, follow, and find out who’s calling.”

Elizabeth stared at her hands, still tingling from the memory of a missing heartbeat. She lifted her chin, resolve settling. “Then we follow. Of course.”

She was already moving. “But first—I need to check something.”

Before he could ask, she hauled herself up the side of the train. Ash whirled in the wind; smoke curled over the roofline. With a muttered sigh and the ghost of a smile, the Doctor followed. Together, they climbed onto the roof.

Elizabeth pushed ahead, boots clanging on the metal. Smoke drifted low, shrouding the cars in ember and ash. The Doctor leapt the gap behind her, coat flaring like a banner.

“Where exactly are we going?” he called, half curious, half impatient.

She glanced back with a teasing smile. “Not knowing everything isn’t much fun, is it?”

His mouth twitched. “All right—tell me something else. Where are you from?”

They jumped the next gap. Elizabeth fought the wind—hair whipping her face—while the Doctor landed with the careless ease of a man who’d done this too many times to count.

Falling into step beside him, she laughed, breathless. “I’m from here. Now you tell me—what’s a New Time Lord?”

He tilted his head, a glint of mischief in his eyes. “My people—the old Time Lords—were from Gallifrey. My oldest friend, the Master, wiped us out and used a machine to make sure we couldn’t have children. The ‘New Time Lords’ are a race called the Trewrach. They sifted through the rubble of my people, stole their technology, and crowned themselves the New Time Lords.”

Elizabeth stopped, sadness in her eyes as he kept walking. “Wait—you’re the last of your species?”

He turned, smiling like it didn’t hurt. “It wouldn’t be the first time. But if you’re counting… yes. I’m the last of the old Time Lords.”

She ran to him and hugged him. His arms hovered awkwardly at his sides, then lifted, uncertain. “I’m sorry for your loss, How did you survive?” she whispered.

“When we’re children, they show us the Time Vortex. Some kids run; some go mad; some see the universe turn. I just never stopped running.” he said gently. “We keep moving forward.”

She let go, hopped to the next carriage, and he followed.

"How old are you?" he asked.

Elizabeth stared. "You're joking."

"Nope." He skipped the next gap like a curb. "I'm older than your country. Older than your wars. Older than the sky you're breathing." He drew in the air as if to prove it.

"That makes no sense," she said, picking her way over the fourth carriage. "You look late twenties, early thirties. How can you be older than the sky?"

"The old Time Lords have a trick," he said, light again. "Regeneration. New face, new body."

"So that energy coming off you when you first woke up—"

"Biogenesis," he corrected softly. "It'll try to keep this body going as long as it can." His tone hardened for a heartbeat, then brightened. "But enough about me. Why did you follow me?"

Elizabeth's lips pressed thin. "Why does it matter?"

He sidestepped a loose panel, hands in his pockets. "I've never heard your answer."

They reached the fifth and final carriage. The engine loomed ahead, the hatch glinting with soot and rivets. Elizabeth paused, fingertips brushing the lock, her face caught between defiance and something softer.

"Because I've patched up a lot of soldiers," she said. "I've seen everything—bullet holes, burns. But your eyes looked old. Older than anyone I've ever seen. I thought I saw... someone different." She hesitated, then added, "Oh—and I'm twenty-three."

The Doctor stopped dead. The number seemed to hang in the smoke. Grief, wonder, calculation flickered across his face—then he folded it all away behind a smile that didn't quite reach his eyes.

"Twenty-three," he echoes, distant. "Barely a heartbeat."

Elizabeth crouches, tugging at the hatch, but it refuses to move. "Doctor, I need your help."

He doesn't answer. He's staring at her, lost in some faraway reckoning of centuries against her single year.

"Doctor!" she snaps, sharper this time. "What are you doing back there?"

He blinks, shakes it off, and strides forward. Together they grip the hatch; the metal groans and gives way, smoke belching up from below.

Elizabeth drops through first, boots hitting the floor of the engine room. The Doctor follows, landing light beside her.

She shoots him a look. "Next time you want to brood about my age, at least open the door first."



He smiles faintly, alien and human all at once, before his eyes harden again—ready for whatever waits in the dark below.

The Doctor and Elizabeth drop into the carriage. Dust settles, the air thick with the echo of silence. The Doctor pivots, eyes scanning the rows of empty benches.

“They’ve taken everyone,” he mutters. “The microbots. Someone’s not building an army—they’re stealing one.”

Elizabeth pushes open the narrow door at the front. Her voice leaps out, bright with relief. “Fly Boy!”

Frank is there—alive, grinning—catching her in his arms and spinning her once before setting her back down. “You all right? I don’t know what happened back there—some kind of black smoke, running over everyone, like it was taking control.”

Behind them, the Doctor paces, muttering half to himself, half to the universe. “No... wrong. When I first met her, she was twenty-five. Year was 2028. Now she’s twenty-three, standing here. Who is she—then and now?”

Elizabeth frowns at him but turns back to Frank. “Why didn’t the bots come for you?”

Frank shakes his head. “I don’t know. I stayed up front. I heard shouting, screaming... and then nothing. I thought if I kept still, whatever it was might pass me by.”

The Doctor stops dead, eyes narrowing as he studies Frank. “You’re not injured, are you?”

Frank blinks. “No. Why does that matter?”

The Doctor wheels toward Elizabeth, his voice urgent now. “Think about it. In the future, Jacob and Amelia only took over the injured. They needed wounds, weak spots, places to crawl inside.”

Elizabeth’s breath catches. “So... the bots can only infect people who are already hurt.”

“Exactly!” The Doctor’s grin is sharp, his eyes alight. “They were medical bots once—built to heal. Someone’s rewritten them, repurposed them into parasites. Oh, very clever. Very cruel. An army stitched from the wounded.”

He turns on his heel, already moving fast, coat flaring behind him. “Come on!”

Elizabeth and Frank share a startled look, then race after him—boots hammering against the floorboards, breath clouding in the sooty air—as the Doctor throws open the door to the final carriage.

At first it looks ordinary: crates stacked high, canvas tarps draped in dust. But the Doctor doesn’t hesitate. He strides to the far wall, sonic screwdriver buzzing in his hand. With a flick and a flash, the boards shimmer, dissolve—revealing coils of wire and a tall bank of

humming glass cylinders. The air hums with static. A teleporter, disguised as the back of the train.

The Doctor steps inside, eyes already scanning controls. “Ah. Beautifully concealed. Always hiding in plain sight.”

Elizabeth and Frank follow, gazing at the glowing chamber. Elizabeth folds her arms. “So how are you going to find them?”

The Doctor grins, tugging a lever. “By chasing the echo of their last jump.” Sparks shower as the sonic pries open a panel, revealing a web of circuits. His tone darkens as his hands keep working.

“And I know where the microbots came from. Year 3405. Planet Neutron. A place of peace—half its surface hospitals, the rest gardens. Pilgrims, healers, wanderers... anyone searching for quiet. Until the heist. They lost everything. Their stockpile of medical bots stolen, their economy ruined. Peace turned to ash.”

Elizabeth’s voice is quiet. “Who would do that?”

The Doctor looks up, meeting their eyes—Elizabeth steady, Frank pale but resolute. His expression softens, a thread of loneliness cutting through his fire. “That’s what we’re going to find out.”

He straightens, dusts his hands, and gestures toward the console. “But this isn’t just my fight. Once I pull this lever, there’s no turning back. So—” His voice lifts, teasing but serious. “Do you want to come along?”

Elizabeth hesitates, searching his face. Frank shifts, glancing at her, then back at the machine. The air is heavy with choice.

Finally, Elizabeth lifts her chin. “Yes.”

Frank nods, voice rough but certain. “Me too.”



## What Have They Done To You

The Doctor's grin spreads, wide and brilliant, lit with something ancient and fierce. "Good. Very good."

He throws the lever. Light explodes, the floor lurches, and thunder cracks through the air. The three of them blur into brilliance—vanishing together into the unknown.

The Doctor hauls himself upright, brushing ash from his coat. Around them stretches a skeletal chamber—walls bare to the girders, cables hanging like veins.

Frank's voice is small against the vast metal shell. "Where are we?"

The Doctor sweeps his sonic across the dark, reading the hum in the wires. "Well... according to this—New Earth. Year 4020."

Elizabeth tilts her head. "New Earth?"

He nods absently, still scanning. "Humans, of course. Once they cracked commercial space travel, they rename every sky—New Earth, New New York, New Cardiff—little echoes of home."

He stops. His voice catches.

The TARDIS lies on her side, half-buried in cables. Blue paint dulled, light dim, wires plugged into her like leeches. Energy pulses through her hull straight into the teleporter.

The Doctor bolts forward, dropping to his knees. "Oh, you brilliant, battered thing... what have they done to you?"

Frank squints. "What is that?"

The Doctor smiles sadly as he pushes the door open. "My oldest friend." He slips inside without another word.

Elizabeth stares. "What the—where did he go?"

She grips Frank's hand and pulls him forward. Together they climb toward the skewed doorway. Inside, gravity tilts sideways, but the Doctor is racing around the console room as though nothing's wrong—hands flying across levers, his feet dancing at impossible angles.

Elizabeth gapes. "No... how are you doing this?"

The Doctor straightens, grinning. "It's not me. It's the TARDIS. My ship. My home."

Frank frowns, leaning in. "But it's upside down. How's it—how's it defying the laws of gravity?"

"Stand back." The Doctor's tone sharpens.

Elizabeth tugs Frank with her, retreating from the doorway. The cables shudder. One by one, they snap free from the TARDIS. Sparks flare. Then the ship itself begins to flicker, fading in and out like a candle guttering in wind. Backwards. Forwards. Until—

Gone.

"Doctor!" Elizabeth cries, panic flooding her face.

Frank swallows hard. "I think... I think he just left us."

Elizabeth shakes her head, fierce. "No. He's not the type to run from a fight."

A groan of engines. A rush of impossible sound. The TARDIS flickers back into existence before them, whole and glowing, her blue light burning through the dark. Elizabeth's face lights up with a smile. Frank just stares, breathless.

The door creaks open. The Doctor strides out, shutting it firmly behind him. "Sorry. Systems check. She's a time-and-space machine, not meant to be wired up like a pass-through generator."

Elizabeth blinks. "Wait—did you just say time machine?"

Frank points. "And did you just say it travels through space?"

The Doctor ignores them both. He's already examining the chamber walls, sonic buzzing. His face darkens. "This isn't just a teleporter. This—" He gestures to a massive hub of cables glowing red. "This is the converter. Clever, very clever. They couldn't build their own time machine, so they're hijacking mine. Draining her. Using the TARDIS as the battery—the beating heart of the whole system."

He finally looks back, eyes distant and sharp. "Sorry—what was it you said?"

The Doctor strides past Elizabeth and Frank, coat brushing their shoulders. Frank shoots Elizabeth a look. "You said that blue box is a time machine?"

The Doctor half-turns, smiling. "Yes. A time machine. Fun fact—she wasn't always a police box. The chameleon circuit broke centuries ago. Now she's stuck as a little blue box with ideas far bigger than her frame."

He keeps walking, scanning the walls with his sonic.

Frank hurries after. "And you said it travels through space as well?"

The Doctor stops, pivots on his heel, eyes glinting. "Yes. She has a name: the TARDIS. Acronym. Time And Relative Dimension In Space."

Elizabeth studies him, brow furrowed. "You don't look afraid. You look... comfortable. Like this is just another day for you. Is this what you do? All the time?"

The Doctor's smile turns wistful. "Every day. All day. I run. I save who I can. Deliver justice when I must. No weapon. Just two hearts, both stubbornly gold."

He turns and moves on, footsteps echoing.

Frank calls after him. "But how do you know what's right or wrong? Where's the line between justice and injustice?"

The Doctor pauses. His shoulders lift, then fall. "Someone has to make a choice." His voice is soft, final. Then he pushes the door ahead and steps through.

On the other side: a warehouse. Soldiers packed in rows, eyes pitch black, bodies unnervingly still.

Elizabeth edges closer to the Doctor, but Frank lingers back, his voice low. "He's dangerous. A man who decides for everyone else what's right and wrong... someone with that much power can't be trusted."

Elizabeth turns sharply. "Don't you see it? The hope. The chance that the world could be better—because he's here. Because he fights."

Frank shakes his head. "People always have agendas. Reasons for what they do. Don't fool yourself—he has his too."

Elizabeth's hand finds his, steady. "People farm to feed their families. Their agenda is survival, their reason is love. That's not a bad agenda. So why assume his must be?"

Before Frank can answer, metal slams. The door between them seals shut, locking Elizabeth and Frank out—leaving the Doctor alone inside with the black-eyed soldiers.

The Doctor moves quietly across the warehouse floor, sonic screwdriver buzzing as he scans the motionless soldiers. Their uniforms are a jumble—British troops from the 1940s, alien warriors from distant stars—all standing shoulder to shoulder, eyes blank.

Then the door slams shut behind him.

A slow clap echoes overhead. The Doctor tilts his head up. A lone figure stands silhouetted on the gantry above.

“Well done, Doctor,” the man calls.

The soldiers collapse in unison, thudding to the floor. The Doctor stands alone, surrounded.

He lowers the sonic. “And who are you?”

The man in a red coat with a hood covering his face lounged against the railing, voice calm and mocking. “I’ve had many names, like you: the Oncoming Storm, the Hybrid, the Doctor of War.”

The Doctor narrowed his eyes. “And what do you call yourself now?”

A beat. “Bob. The Soldier of Time.”

The Doctor blinked. “Bob?” His mouth twitched. “I was expecting something... grander. The Master. The Rani. Someone with a bit of theatre.”

Bob chuckled. “No. None of those. And I’m older than they are, Doctor—much older.”

The Doctor’s jaw tightened as he glanced at the fallen soldiers. “What was the point of all this death?”

Bob leaned on the rail. “I need more bodies.”

The Doctor swept his gaze over the gathered races. “Bodies for what? To start another war?”

Bob laughed. “I’ve lived long enough to know wars only redraw lines. What I’m aiming for will rebalance the universe.”

“Why?” the Doctor asked quietly.

Bob turned and began to walk away. “Because they took everything from me. The New Time Lords and the Old—both stole my past. So I’ll steal their futures.”

The bodies stir. One by one, the soldiers begin to rise again.

The Doctor bolts for the door, sonic raised. The lock hisses, the door slides open—and he bursts through into chaos.

Elizabeth and Frank are fighting off soldiers spilling into the corridor. The Doctor snatches Elizabeth’s hand. “Run!”

Frank stumbles after them as the Doctor whirls, firing the sonic at the door. It slams shut, but black-eyed soldiers force it back open, hands gripping the frame.

They sprint down the hallway. The Doctor's voice rings urgent over the thunder of their boots. "Get to the TARDIS! I can shut down the microbots—give the soldiers, the aliens, all of them peace! But not from here."

He flicks the sonic toward the TARDIS. Circuits hum. The TARDIS shudders, her doors swinging open.

Elizabeth skids to a halt, staring at him. "I don't want to leave you."

The Doctor meets her eyes for a heartbeat, then looks at Frank. Frank grips Elizabeth's arm and pulls her forward. Together they dash into the TARDIS, the doors slamming behind them just as soldiers close in.

Inside, they stop dead—staring.

Elizabeth whispers, awestruck, "It's... bigger on the inside."

Frank circles slowly, eyes wide. "Massive. It's like... endless."

The engines groan. The floor shakes.

Suddenly the doors creak open. Frank stumbles outside—onto the last carriage of the train in 1940. Smoke. Steam. Familiar rails. He stares back at the impossibility.

"It's smaller on the outside," he breathes.

Elizabeth races out after him, laughing, joy lighting her face. She runs a circle around the blue box. "Two different sizes—inside and out—how is that even possible?"

The doors slam shut. The TARDIS begins to fade, blinking in and out.

Elizabeth's smile falters. "Doctor! You can't do this!"

Frank grabs her arm, desperate. "Elizabeth, there's nothing you can—"

But she's already moving. With sudden resolve, she leaps, catching the outside rail of the TARDIS door just as the ship vanishes completely. As she shouts, "No one left behind. Like you Doctor, I'm running, but I'm running to you."

Frank freezes, stunned, staring at the empty track. Silence swallows him.

He whispers to no one, "How am I supposed to explain this? The only one left... on this train?"

Elizabeth's voice returns from the dark.

“While the Doctor runs to his blue box, the Legend of Three takes its first true breath. The Doctor knows there’s only one thing he can do—the thing he’s always done: run.”